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A Voice of Its Own

Utilizing voice as an expressive tool in *Killing 'R'*

Written reflection within independent work
The documentation also includes the following audio files:

Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 1.mp3
Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 2.mp3
Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 3.mp3
Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 4.mp3
Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 5.mp3
Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 6.mp3
Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 7.mp3

And the video file:

Killing R (H264).mov

KMH Kungl. Musikhögskolan

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I Background

Ia. The human voice in film music

> The human voice is really the foundation of all music. It is the original instrument, and in many ways remains the most expressive.[1]

This observation by Deryck Cooke explains why voice has been at the center of musical expression, composition and performance since the dawn of musical history. Styles and techniques have constantly evolved, serving as a 'foundation of musical traditions across cultures and centuries'.[2] In the early Western music tradition, while voice was principally treated as a melodic instrument, some composers experimented with vocal technique. Composers like Claudio Monteverdi (1567 - 1643) used exaggerated vocal effects to reflect the meaning of the text, a technique now referred to as 'word painting' and associated strongly with 16th-century madrigals: ascending scales would be utilized for words like "rising" or "heaven", dissonance and chromaticism for words related to pain, sorrow, or death.[3]

The 20th century brought a radical transformation, with the voice evolving into a far more versatile and expressive tool. Composers explored and recontextualized various singing styles and their cultural and historical associations, as well as the possibilities offered by extended vocal techniques and digital processing. Among the pioneers in this regard we can count Luciano Berio (1925 - 2003), whose *Sequenza III* for voice (1965) revolutionized vocal music calling for 'expression such as humming, whispering, speaking, breathing and mouth sounds in addition to singing that is driven to exaltation'.[4]

Karlheinz Stockhausen (1928 - 2007) also pushed the boundaries of what the human voice could achieve. In works like *Stimmung* (1968) he explored overtone singing, speech-singing

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[1] D. Cooke, *The Language of Music*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1959, p. 112.

[2] D. J. Grout and C. V. Palisca, *A history of Western music*, 7th edn., New York, W.W. Norton & Company, 2006, p. 15.

[3] S. Sadie and T. Carter, *Word Painting*, The New Grove Dictionary of Music and Musicians, 2nd edn., London, Macmillan, 2001, vol. 27.

[4] Musik Salon UE, *Experiment and discourse: Luciano Berio's "Sequenze"* [website], https://musiksalon.universaledition.com/en/article/experiment-und-diskurs-luciano-berios-sequenze-kopie, (accessed 23 January 2025).

(*Sprechgesang*), and percussive vocal effects.[5] Stockhausen was also a pioneer in amplifying the expressive capabilities of the voice through technology such as tape recorders and audio effects. With technological advancements, the possibilities have increased dramatically, and artists continue to develop innovative applications of vocal processing, setting new trends. Take for instance the *vocal drop* that dominated pop music in the late 2010's replacing the tradition chorus:

> The singer literally drops out, replaced by synthesizers and chopped-up, distorted vocal samples that vaguely reference the earlier lyrics. There is no need to sing along. Paired with a syncopated beat, the pop-drop invites the listener to just feel the music in a way that's unexpected, revelatory and just plain fun.[6]

Throughout cinema's relatively short history, musical traditions and trends—from the concert hall to folk and popular music—have consistently found their way into film scores. Vocal music played a particularly prominent role in the early days of cinema, with songs and choral performances frequently accompanying silent film screenings. With the advent of sound, cinemas were often dominated by 'adaptations of Broadway musical comedies, revues and operettas', among other reasons due to the 'novelty of on-screen performances of celebrities', as Katherine Spring suggests.[7] Later the *theme song* emerged, that the rest of the score would center around, repurposing the motives and melodies: A noticeable example is the song *Moon River* by Henry Mancini for *Breakfast at Tiffanies* in 1961.[8]

As modernist music gained prominence in the concert hall, it soon made its way into mainstream cinema. In the 60s and 70s Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* and *The Shining* famously incorporate the dissonant, otherworldly choral textures of modernist composer György Ligeti (1923–2006)—a sound that has since become a cinematic shorthand for tension, unease, and horror. Similarly, Jóhann Jóhannsson's 2016 score for Denis Villeneuve's *Arrival* draws on minimalist traditions of the 1970s, using short, repeating vocal motifs to echo the film's themes of language, time, and alien perception.[9]

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[5] Karl Heinz Stockhouse, *Zusatztext 1997 zu Stimmung* [website], http://www.karlheinzstockhausen.org/zusatz_stimmung_german.htm, (accessed 23 January 2025).

[6] Billboard, *How the Pop-Drop Became the Sound of 2016* [website], https://www.billboard.com/music/music-news/pop-drop-sound-of-2016-chainsmokers-justin-bieber-switched-on-pop-7625628/, (accessed 23 January 2025).

[7] K. Spring, *Saying it with songs: popular music and the coming of sound to Hollywood cinema*, New York, Oxford University Press, 2014, p. 2.

[8] Film Reference, *The use of Popular Songs* [website], http://www.filmreference.com/encyclopedia/Independent-Film-Road-Movies/Music-THE-USE-OF-POPULAR-SONG.html, (accessed 23 January 2025).

[9] S. Gharib, 'Villeneuve's Arrival', *Cinematic Codes Review*, Vol. 4, Iss. 3, 2019.

Film music has also embraced and adapted non-Western musical influences, resulting in hybrid ethnic styles. Some of these stylistic fusions have become part of a standardized cinematic language, frequently employed to evoke specific geographical locations or cultural atmospheres. For instance, to represent desert landscapes or Middle Eastern settings, composers often incorporate vocal lines that draw on Arabic-inspired inflections and modal scales. A recent example is Hans Zimmer's soundtrack for the 2021 film *Dune*, which draws on these musical elements to enrich its otherworldly atmosphere. Sometimes film composers utilize non-Western vocal styles with less obvious relations to the settings and more abstract creative intentions: For *The golden compass* for instance, composer Alexandre Desplat utilized tuvan throat singing, because 'in the film, this sound symbolizes the freedom from the system control (Magisterium), [...] a very striking association, because harmonics shift the perception into the right brain hemisphere, and thus beyond the control from outside.'[10]

The voice thus has extremely versatile functions in film music: it is both a 'musical instrument and a conveyor of meaning', capable of expressing raw emotion white utilizing natural, historical and cultural associations as narrative devices.[11]

Ib. Vocal music and female representation

Despite decades of innovation, many Western film scores still draw on narrative structures and stylistic conventions inherited from the symphonic tradition. Within this context, the use of the human voice is often influenced by historically embedded associations—particularly those related to gender. Although gender representation in Western classical traditions was complex, nuanced and far from uniform, these legacies continue to shape dominant trends in film music today. For example, they help explain the recurring use of the female voice to signify an 'otherworldly quality, evoking emotions that range from vulnerability to transcendence' reinforcing themes of 'longing, loss, or spiritual awakening'.[12] Furthermore by 'employing the female voice as a leitmotif, composers often underscore the emotional journey of female protagonists, [...] their internal struggles and triumphs.[13] A typical example can be found in Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982), scored by composer Vangelis

[10] Oberton, *Harmonics in The Golden Compass Film Score* [website], https://www.oberton.org/en/obertoene-im-goldenen-kompass/, (accessed 23 January 2025).

[11] M. Chion, *Audio-Vision: Sound on Screen*, New York, Columbia University Press, 1994, p. 127.

[12] K. Kalinak, *Settling the Score: Music and the Classical Hollywood Film* , Madison, Wis., University of Wisconsin Press, 1992, p. 135.

[13] C. Flinn, *Strains of Utopia: Gender, Nostalgia, and Hollywood Film Music*, Princeton, N.J., Princeton University Press, 1992, p. 176.

(1943–2022). While the soundtrack is largely characterized by sombre, industrial electronic textures, *Rachel's Song*—the theme of the protagonist's love interest—stands out for its lyrical and ethereal quality. It features an angelic soprano voice that floats delicately above ambient synthesizer layers, evoking vulnerability and emotional depth within the film's futuristic soundscape.

In recent years, societal shifts—including the impact of the #MeToo movement in Hollywood and the increasing visibility of female film composers—have significantly influenced the representation of women in film scores. These developments are reflected not only in the narrative themes surrounding female characters but also in the musical language used to portray them. In Natalie Holt's score for *Loki* (2021) the use of experimental synths and theremin to represent Sylvie – a powerful female variant of Loki – breaks away from traditional "feminine" scoring, giving her a distinct and unconventional musical identity.[14] The central leitmotiv for the planet Arrakis in Hans Zimmer's *Dune* score is a female vocal chant, reflecting the matriarchal society of the Fremen. Films like these illustrate a shift toward empowering narratives for female characters and invite viewers to connect more deeply with a variety of female experiences.

Vocal music can not only amplify female representation but also reflect shifting societal perspectives, challenge traditional notions of femininity, and foster a dynamic dialogue about gender and narrative agency. This is a fascinating topic of much research and discussion in art and gender literature, but I won't go deeper into it here.

Ic. Killing 'R'

As part of a collaborative project with students from SKH (Stockholm University of the Arts), I composed the score for the exam film *Killing 'R'*, directed and co-written by Master's student Irene Lopez. The film was produced in the spring of 2023 and has since then been released on the streaming platform *SVT Play* as well as several festivals including the Gothenburg and the Norwegian film festival. Set in a fictional future, the story follows Rebecca, a working mother who delegates her domestic responsibilities—including the care of her daughter—to a clone of herself, known as 'R', in order to focus on an important work deadline. At first, Rebecca enjoys the newfound freedom and flexibility, but soon realizes that her identity as a mother and wife is being subtly eroded. A dystopian dark satire, Killing R critiques modern society, consumerism, and traditional notions of motherhood and femininity. It also offers a stark warning about the possible trajectory of our future.

[14] Composer, *Natalie Holt on Creating the Score for Loki, Marvel's God of Mischief* [website], https://composer.spitfireaudio.com/en/articles/natalie-holt-on-creating-the-score-for-loki-marvels-god-of-mischief, (accessed 23 January 2025).

II Hypothesis

Early manuscript drafts and discussion about the narrative themes revealed that the film offered interesting opportunities to utilize voice as a means to musically reflect the characters, concepts and structure of the story. This thesis investigates how the human voice, when processed and contextualized through electronic techniques, can reflect gender subversion, uncanny atmospheres, and the suppression of the natural in dystopian cinema.

IIa. Subversion of gender

Roland Barthes states that 'the voice is not just sound; it is the audible trace of the body, a unique sonic fingerprint that reveals identity, emotion, and physical presence.'[15] This idea is central to voice and embodiment theory, which explores the deep connection between the human voice, the body, identity, and social context. Scholars like Nina Sun Eidsheim even argue that the voice is not inherently gendered but is instead interpreted through culturally conditioned listening practices that assign it gendered meaning.[16]

With this in mind, the human voice presents an interesting starting point in the representation of 'R'. By utilizing processed voice I planned to capture her near human, yet eerie, essence, her engineered, synthetic body but also to signal her deeper symbolic meaning in the narrative. While 'R' on first glance appears physically a woman, identical to Rebecca, she is in fact an idealized version of Rebecca, without bruises or blemishes, and in her manner and function an extension of a patriarchal understanding of women, and their role in society and family. Hence, in some sense, I fully embraced the 'patriarchal framework' of the western classical tradition that Claudia Gorbman discusses in relation to traditional film music.[17] 'R's' voice becomes a sonic tool of subversion, weaponizing the very tropes it embodies. By subtly inflecting the vocal sounds representing 'R' with a "male-like" quality, e.g. through the process of format shifting, I could manipulate the perception of her gender and, in turn, her narrative role. Processing could be applied gradually as 'R' increasingly reveals her true nature over the course of the film.

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[15] R. Barthes, *Image music text*, trans. S. Heath, New York, Hill and Wang, 1977, p. 182.

[16] N. S. Eidsheim, *The Race of Sound: Listening, Timbre, and Vocality in African American Music*, Durham, Duke University Press, 2019.

[17] C. Gorbman, *Unheard Melodies: Narrative Film Music*, Bloomington, Indiana University Press, 1987, p. 91.

An intriguing question also arose around whose voice should musically represent “R.” Should it be Rebecca’s own voice—that of the actress herself—or an external one? And should that voice be female or male? I aimed to explore different options and compare findings during the process.

IIb. Expressing the uncanny

The human voice is a powerful tool for crafting deeply unsettling music, as it resonates with audiences on a profoundly psychological level—a technique long exploited in horror films. *Killing R* has a dark and eerie narrative, and I believed that the way I process and manipulate voice could play a central role in amplifying the film’s unsettling tone. Beyond representing 'R', I aimed to musically underscore the dark setting utilizing layered whispers, time-stretched breathing and dissonances to unsettle and evoke a subconscious recognition of a hidden threat and something being "off", turning the voice into a carrier of both character and commentary.

IIc. Suppression of the natural

The futuristic, dystopian setting of the film itself is one in which society fetishizes nature: Houses are decorated throughout with plants and symbols of the natural world. However, beyond this highly controlled, stylized and superficial embrace, it is apparent that humans are living removed from the real natural world, including their own nature. This perverted relationship with and suppressed longing for nature I wanted to capture in subverting (i.e. processing) voice in the broadest sense, including animal noises and other natural ambience sounds (the voice of nature). By processing and combining field recordings I hoped to create interesting sustain pads, rhythms and textures to create a suitable musical sound world.

III Pre-Production

Killing R as a project offered a unique opportunity to be involved from a very early stage in the development process—something I rarely experience in my professional work and would consider a rare luxury. Being brought in so early opened up a wide range of creative possibilities. It allowed for substantial input (Irene was very receptive to suggestions on her script) and provided time to explore unconventional ideas and untested approaches. However, working from abstract conversations and an evolving script also posed certain risks. There was always the chance that some ideas would prove redundant once the edited footage—with its specific visual language, pacing, and tone—came into focus, potentially requiring a complete rethinking of the musical direction.

At this stage, I maintained regular dialogue with Irene and sound mixer Petar Mjrden. Petar had quite particular sound concepts of his own. For instance, he imagined homes of the future to be dominated by sounds / jingles from various devices and machinery in the house. This was certainly an interesting idea and care would have to be taken so that music would not interfere with its impact. The soundtrack could in fact embrace this idea further and incorporate motives / themes from the various jingles in interesting ways. Based on discussions with Irene and Petar, I began gathering potential musical references and invited the rest of the team to do the same. I approached this phase with an open mind, eager to be inspired and surprised. Among the references I explored were the soundtracks to *The White Lotus* by Cristobal Tapia de Veer and several scores by Trent Reznor, including *Gone Girl* and *The Social Network*. I shared selected excerpts with Irene, and we found that several musical characteristics resonated with her vision: processed voice, subtle instrumentation, eerie electroacoustic textures, and recurring rhythmic motifs.

Importantly, this exercise also helped us establish a shared musical vocabulary—clarifying what we each meant when referring to music as “epic,” “punk,” or other stylistic labels. This common language became a vital foundation for future discussions and creative alignment. From there, I began developing a series of musical sketches, experimenting with a range of tools, techniques, and conceptual directions.

IIIa. Tools

My own voice served as a useful tool when exploring vocal possibilities. While I am far from being a trained vocalist, I learned a lot by recording myself, singing with different “characters”, inflections, vowels, covering a range of phrases, noises and staccato rhythms. There are of course commercial sample libraries out there, including for example Spitfire’s *Xtended Vox* that offer access to a vast range of avant garde voice performances, ready-to-play via midi keyboard. However, in the spirit of learning and experimentation, as well as the project's needs, I instead started to create my own, bespoke sample library.

I also acquainted myself (and reacquainted myself) with a host of software tools and plugins that might serve me in achieving my creative objective. For vocal processing some that proved very promising were:

- *Waves CR8 is a relatively straightforward sampler that allows for pitching, reversing, time-stretching, and pitch-flattening across eight independent sample layers. By loading vocal samples into the sampler and experimenting with them in an improvised manner—manipulating parameters in real time and automating effects—I was able to generate warped, eerie, and often unpredictable melodic and rhythmic textures. This process led me to create my own custom virtual instruments based on vocal material, which I then performed using a MIDI keyboard.*

- *Omnisphere 2* provides many processing options of user samples, especially granular synthesis. I used the granular processing to experiment with creating ambient layers, using vocal samples as base. I liked the harmonic ambiguity / complexity that arose in the textures, and saw strong potential for the film

- *Steinberg Pitchcorrect* is a vocal pitch correction plug-in that has interesting creative uses: one can shift the tonal qualities and formants of the input voice. WIth some tweaking, I managed to process my own voice until it had a fairly female quality.

- *Soundtoys altar boy* is a dedicated formant shift effect that produces quite natural results with few artifacts when not pushed to the extreme.

IIIb Experimental Sketches

In order to explore these tools I recorded a little library of improvised vocal melodies, rhythmic figures and effects with my own voice. I wasn't particularly methodical here but rather tried to find the range of possibilities.

The results of subtle, continuously varied formant shifting held promise: The voice maintained a melodious, dynamic quality, yet had an outworldly, androgynous character. I particularly like the effect on vocal lines where I had modulated the vowel sound when recording. *Attachment 1* (see appendix) is an early sketch that highlights such processed vocal recordings. *Attachment 2* is built on the same sketch but highlights more extensive pitch shifting and chopping of vocal samples, resulting in a very synthetic, near robotic character.

By layering a few vocal lines together and then running these through Omnispheres granular synthesis, I created some interesting ambient texture, consisting of moving / modulating layers with an organic, yet uncanny quality. *Attachment 3* highlights one result from this approach.

Playing my vocal sample patches on CR8 I created some interesting polyphonic choral sketches. The opening track *the clone solution* (*attachment 4*) was realized this way.

Beyond vocal sounds I also conducted some explorative field recording sessions, using diverse objects from SKH's rather large collection in the Radio Studio. This resulted in a collection of rhythmical textures, hits and dark, dissonant timbres. I received inspiration from Hildegard Westerkamp's *Beneath the Forest Floor* (1992), an electroacoustic composition I heard at a school concert. The piece uses nature recordings such as birdsong, water, wind etc. transformed through effects including filtering, time-stretching, and reverb, to create an immersive soundscape that evokes the hidden, resonant world beneath the forest floor.[18]

I experimented with processing and layering my recordings using the above tools, leading to some interesting soundscapes and sound effects. *Attachment 5* is one such soundscape. I combined the different elements, processed voice, ambient layers and sequenced / processed field recordings into a series of sketches, with different tones and moods ready to present for the next phase.

[18] H. Westerkamp, 'Linking soundscape composition and acoustic ecology', *Organised Sound*, vol. 7, no. 1, 2002, pp. 51–56.

IIIc. Test Film

As part of pre-production, the students at SKH produced a 5 minute test film, in order to try certain workflows and techniques. The film contained essentially one continuous scene from the main script, focusing on Rebecca's home routines and her frustrating interactions with 'R'.

In discussion with Irene it became soon clear that she wasn't very happy with the result and didn't feel that it represented her vision well. The tone was pretty comedic in nature, while she would have liked to go with something darker. This hampered the effectiveness of the film for testing my musical ideas. Irene was generally positive about my concepts and experimental sketches, though, and she liked the combination of warped, synthetic vocal melodic fragments with organic dissonant soundscapes. This created tension in the scene, yet maintained a degree of ambiguity which allowed the subtle undertones of the narrative to come through.

Sound mixer Petar used the test film to try out many of his sonic ideas all at once. The result was certainly interesting, but lacked a consistent vision and overloaded the sonic space. It was clear that we would have to coordinate closely, and together with Irene formulate a clear sonic vision going forward. This vision should then be tested as early as possible in post-production as edits became available.

IV Production

During the summer and autumn of 2022, pre-production gained momentum, with the script undergoing constant revisions. As the tone and vision of the film evolved, my contact with Irene and the team became sporadic. It was still too early to define a concrete musical direction beyond abstract, exploratory conversations, so I made a conscious decision to conserve creative energy for the later stages, when the narrative and visual language would be more clearly established.

I eventually received the final version of the script about a week before the shoot. By then, the tone had shifted towards a more naturalistic style with subtle dark-comedic undertones—closer to the original vision Irene had described early on. Notably, two scenes were now written with explicit musical focus: a slow-motion opening sequence (functioning as a kind of overture) and a dance scene. The latter came as a surprise, particularly because Irene needed temp music for the shoot and had no specific reference at hand. She shared a handful of tracks that varied widely in style, tempo, and

genre, underscoring the fact that the musical direction for this moment was still quite open. Establishing a suitable reference required several conversations with Irene, as well as input from the choreographer, Aleksandra Sende. It became clear that the dance scene was more of a choreographed, chaotic drunken frenzy, and at this stage, the music's primary role was to provide raw energy and an erratic beat to drive the action.

On the day of the shoot, I visited the set with a few potential music options. After discussing with the team, we agreed on the anarchic tribal dance track *Storm* by the band Otyken, which matched the wild, unhinged energy of the scene well.

V Post-Production

Post Production started in earnest February 2023. The team was presented with a *script cut* (an edit following the script closely) but It became quite evident that Irene was not satisfied with it and began experimenting with re-edits. This posed continuing challenges for me, remaining in the dark about the structure, style and pace of the film. I sensed that in order to avoid much redundant work and frustration, it would be best to follow a strict, formal process in terms of creative sign-off of the musical cues. This was to document and hold accountable any changes in direction on a somewhat unpredictable, volatile project.

Va. Spotting

In film scoring, *spotting* is the process where the composer, director, and occasionally the sound mixer view the film together to determine the precise moments where music should start and stop—(so called *spotting points*). Usually all this is documented in a *cue sheet*.

Due to the delay of an approved rough cut it was challenging to define the main themes and cues in detail. Instead, the film was locked scene by scene and I agreed on the music direction and cue sheet for each scene with Irene in writing, trying to maintain some structure and my overarching vision.

Vb. Music Production

The initial sketches for the score were based largely on the work on my early experiments and were written removed from the image. I like to work this way initially, as scoring directly to image early stifles my imagination somewhat. Once satisfied with the direction I placed these sketches to the

visuals and refined the tracks. I primarily worked in Cubase, my preferred digital audio workstation, producing most of the music “in the box” using software instruments, plugins, and effects. This was complimented with a few recordings from my Korg hardware synth.

Initially I had the idea to record and process the singing voice of the actress playing ‘R’. This I feel could have been an interesting venue of exploration, throwing up questions about the relationship between the diegetic and non-diegetic, the external and internal sound world. Ultimately, I opted for using a male voice (in this case my own) as I felt it presented a different but equally valid choice: Here the voice of ‘R’ is external to the characters on screen, the voice of the patriarchy framing the entire story. This choice was also more practical to realize given the circumstances. I complimented my original vocal recordings from pre-production with recordings of a professional female vocalist. These recordings were used to create some of the eerie textures but also in order to present Rebecca’s essence in certain cues, a more natural vocal timbre without all the processing applied to ‘R’s voice.

Ideally, I would have loved to experiment more with physical effect units and synth hardware, as the hands-on process often yields more interesting and organic results. However, time constraints and the ever-evolving nature of the project made this impractical. Ultimately I ended up with 3 themes which I want to breakdown and discuss in relation to the concepts mentioned earlier:

R - the clone solution (*attachment 4*)

This is the highly ironic intro theme of the film, that presents ‘R’ as a “godsend from heaven” for every modern working mother. It is conceived as a reverend choir piece, but is highly subverted: The voices in the choir are formant-shifted and pitched slightly out of tune. In line with my concept the intention is to lend the voices an eerie, artificial, gender-agnostic quality pointing to ‘R’ and the flawed, dark ideology around her existence. It established a dark ironic undertone of the narrative. This theme plays at the very end of the film drowned in reverb, framing the entire narrative. It is clear that Rebecca, now estranged from her child, bought into a bad dream by utilizing a clone of her to run the household.

Everyday theme *(attachment 6*)

This theme is used when establishing the “normal” day in Rebecca's home. It is sparse and light in the arrangement, tonally ambivalent and based on synths playing steady arpeggios. My intention was to reflect this imagined future, where the natural is fetishized and while high technology runs the household to the clock. There are some interspersed vocal snippets as well, hinting at 'R' and the “normality” she represents.

Rebecca loses it (*attachment 7*)

This is the theme for Rebecca's climactic drunken frenzy. While Irene originally wanted a dance track for this scene, upon seeing the edit it was clear another direction was needed. A low, distorted synth plays slow, emotive phrases reflecting Rebecca's subdued melancholy, while snippets of processed vocal samples are delayed and panned around the stereo space as if 'R's voice is echoing in her head. More rhythms and distorted textured enter as the frenzy builds to a climax. There are also more "human" sounding female screams buried in the track to reflect Rebecca's internal conflict and frustration…her repressed voice that is trying to burst into the open.

Vc. Collaboration with Soundmix

A continuous and clear dialogue between composer and sound mixer is of uttermost importance. If sound design and music pull in different directions 'the emotional balance of a scene can easily be lost in the mix.'[19] My early brainstorm session with Petar had yielded many interesting discussions and ideas. While we knew that many of these would quickly go by the road as production took shape, they presented interesting material for future exploration. One early proposal mentioned earlier involved populating Rebecca's domestic soundscape with digital artefacts—beeps, notifications, and jingles emanating from various appliances—to reflect the hyper-mediated environment in which she lives. However, this approach quickly proved impractical due to its potential to interfere with dialogue sound. We also briefly considered the idea of harmonizing ambient room tones with the musical score to subtly reinforce emotional cues, though time constraints later prevented a full exploration of this technique.

Once the team had 'workable' edits I convened with Petar and ensured that my musical vision and cue sheet did not interfere with his approach to the sound design and mix. We were pretty aligned in terms of where and how music should be placed. This was good news, as sometimes very different visions can result in long discussion, compromises or even creative conflicts. Petar very much bought into the concept of reflecting character's emotional state and narrative function with voice. In certain moments he layered his sound design with exasperated human exhales and screams, highlighting Rebecca's growing frustration and inner turmoil. This was a key method that helped sound and music to form a coherent whole.

During post-production Petar frequently exported versions of his sound treatments to me, so I had an up-to-date reference while producing the score. I delivered all the music in stem format to Petar,

[19] T. Holman, *Sound for film and television* [Elektronic Recourse], 3rd ed., Amsterdam, Focal Press, 2010, p. 203.

giving him maximum flexibility and control at the final mix stage. I attended the final mix, conducted in a cinema, ensuring that my vision was carried through. Sometimes big creative decisions are taken at this stage and I have learned from experience to be present so I can be part of the conversation. I try, however, to maintain an openness to last minute changes in service of the narrative. One interesting observation was the need for more reverb (ie room sound) to ensure that the music sat further back and took the appropriate position in the sonic hierarchy. We also had time to experiment with the 3D panning to maximize the sonic immersion of the film. Irene joined the final mix at the very end and was satisfied with the result.

VI Conclusions

Scoring *Killing R* presented a complex yet invaluable learning experience, offering both substantial creative opportunities and distinct challenges. Early involvement in the project allowed for extensive conceptual exploration and productive collaboration with the director and sound designer. However, the evolving nature of the script and edit demanded flexibility and discipline to sustain a cohesive musical vision amidst shifting narrative and aesthetic parameters.

The process emphasized the importance of balancing informal, intuitive creative experimentation with more structured workflows. Unscripted collaborative “jam” sessions—particularly those conducted in person—proved essential for quickly aligning on ideas and clarifying the director’s intentions. Simultaneously, written documentation of decisions and feedback emerged as a crucial tool for ensuring continuity and shared understanding across the production timeline. Moreover, while open-ended creative brainstorming is essential in early stages, this approach must be balanced with pragmatic decision-making to avoid frustration or inefficiency later in the process.

One major takeaway was the need for greater awareness, among filmmakers, of the specific practical constraints composers face—especially due to the temporal nature of music. Even minor alterations to a scene’s length, pacing, or structure can disrupt musical timing and emotional continuity, often necessitating substantial revisions or complete rewrites. Moving forward, I intend to communicate these challenges more proactively in collaborative settings to prevent misalignment or avoidable setbacks. Another key insight was the crucial importance of early and sustained communication with the sound designer / mixer. Although our collaboration ultimately proved successful, earlier and more structured coordination during post-production could have enabled a deeper integration of sound and

music—potentially allowing for the realization of creative concepts that, in this instance, remained unexplored.

The processed human voice ultimately proved to be an effective and versatile musical tool. It supported the film's dystopian tone while also serving a symbolic function—interrogating patriarchal gender norms and themes of consumerism. Vocal processing techniques were used not only for textural effect but also as a narrative and emotional signifier. For instance:

- A synthetic "choir" of warped vocal sounds served as a sonic metaphor for society's misguided reverence toward technology—reminiscent of religious devotion.

- Repeating fragments of vocal material in the film's climax, juxtaposed with organic female screams, captured the protagonist's internal conflict and growing unease with the relentless intrusion of 'R' into her familial role.

Some initial ideas, such as a gradual transformation of the vocal processing to reflect Rebecca's emotional trajectory, were ultimately not fully realized. These remain promising avenues for further exploration in future work.

The project also revealed areas for improvement in my approach. Time constraints and limited access to analog hardware restricted my ability to engage in hands-on sound manipulation. I believe that deeper involvement with tactile, analog processing methods could have further enriched the sonic palette. Additionally, while I made initial forays into vocal transformation using pitch shifting, formant modulation, and granular synthesis, future work could benefit from exploring a wider array of technologies, such as the visual programming environment *Max/MSP* and specialized vocal processing plugins like *Dehumaniser*. Although these tools are not always designed with musical applications in mind, they offer compelling creative possibilities for film scoring. Likewise, my engagement with extended vocal techniques and timbral variation was limited. Most of the material recorded featured my own, intuitive use of melodic singing without vibrato. A more rigorous, methodical exploration—particularly in collaboration with trained vocalists—would provide a richer understanding of the expressive capacities of the human voice.

Ultimately, *Killing 'R'* served as a compelling case study in the expressive and narrative potential of the human voice in film scoring. Through techniques of vocal processing and recontextualization, the voice became a medium for subversion, psychological resonance, and thematic commentary. Despite certain limitations, the score achieved its central objectives: it supported the narrative arc, deepened

the film's emotional and conceptual layers, and left a distinctive sonic imprint on the final work. The insights gained—both through the composition itself and through the research that accompanied it—will continue to inform my creative practice, particularly in future investigations into the voice as a musical, narrative and cultural tool.

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Appendix - attached files

attachment 1 (*processed voice test 1*) : “Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 1.mp3”

attachment 2 (*processed voice test 2*) : “Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 2.mp3”

attachment 3 (*eerie vocal texture*) : “Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 3.mp3”

attachment 4 (*the clone solution*) : “Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 4.mp3”

attachment 5 (*soundscape from field recordings*) : “Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 5.mp3”

attachment 6 (*everyday theme*) : “Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 6.mp3”

attachment 7 (*Rebecca loses it)* : “Erasmus_Talbot_attachment 7.mp3”

attachment 8 (*The Killing R film)* : “Killing R (H264).mov”